

Chapter Title: No Future for White Men: Nihilism, Fatalism, and Ressentiment

Book Title: In the Ruins of Neoliberalism

Book Subtitle: The Rise of Antidemocratic Politics in the West

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Published by: Columbia University Press

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/10.7312/brow19384.9>

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No Future for White Men

Nihilism, Fatalism, and Ressentiment

Nihilism and Desublimation

Nihilism begins, Nietzsche argues, with the rise of reason and science as challenges to God and other forms of authority, challenges that reveal all meaning to be constructed and all facts to be without inherent meaning. Max Weber calls it “disenchantment.” Tolstoy “descralization”—their different inflections and approaches to the problem converge in agreement that intrinsic value flees the world. However, for Nietzsche, the age of nihilism heralds not the end of values, but a world in which “the highest values devalue themselves” as they are unmoored from their foundations.¹ These values, which include the Christian virtues along with democracy, equality, truth, reason, and accountability, do not vanish as they lose their foundations, but become fungible and trivial, superficial and easily instrumentalized.² This trivialization and instrumentalization, ubiquitous in commercial, political, and even religious life today, further degrade the value of values, which further abets the nihilism . . . an unending spiral shaping political culture and subjectivity.

When a Martin Luther King Jr. speech about public service is used to advertise Dodge trucks during the Super Bowl, when Catholic clergy are revealed to have molested thousands of children while their superiors looked away, when “moral values” politicians are exposed for consorting with prostitutes or making abortion payments for mistresses—these things bring not shock, but a knowing grimace, nihilism’s signature.

However, Nietzsche’s profound account of nihilism was limited by his preoccupation with God and morality as they were being challenged by science and reason. Charting nihilism in this way leaves out the nihilistic force of other human powers that are uncontrolled and imperiling, an order in which the omniscience and omnipotence of both God and man are toppled. Or as Carl Schmitt teaches in his “Dialogue on Power,” almost simultaneous with the recognition that power itself is radically human, that it derives neither from nature nor from God, there is supersession of its containment within and by humans, an end to the dialectic of power/powerlessness. With modernity, Schmitt argues, human power not only loses its human face (kings, barons, militia), but takes novel forms that diffuse and multiply its effects. This diffusion and multiplication means that power comes to be set against everyone, “even the holder of power.”³ It is a multiplying, intensifying force without respect for its creators, exceeding the will to power and any institution or individual.⁴ This also becomes the occasion for resentment, power’s eternal progeny, to diffuse widely, well beyond those who suffer from immediate oppression or deprivation. As power’s historically novel forms and unprecedented ubiquity and uncontainability thwart the mighty and well-placed, along with the

downtrodden, and as it inadvertently vanquishes familiar privileges and forms of life, resentment roams everywhere.

Schmitt's focus was concentrations of power in the nation-state and novel powers of technology such as the atomic bomb: the undirected powers of capital were not on his mind, the unique techniques of administering human life that Foucault called "biopower" were not in his lexicon, and relentless financialization and digitalization had not been born. Together, these powers intensify the problem Schmitt identified and yield one with which he had not reckoned. The paradox of humanly created powers that diminish the human and especially its capacity to shape its world, reaching new intensities just as this capacity is revealed to be all there is—this breeds new quantities and subjects of resentment, and a nihilism beyond Nietzsche's vivid dreams. Again, Nietzsche reflected on the nihilism emanating from the accidental human toppling of the divine; he did not explore formations of power that do not merely trivialize, but openly defile and defy moral values.

There is more. The economizing side of neoliberalism added force to the nihilism of the age and also quickened it, first in leaving nothing untouched by entrepreneurialization and monetization and then, with financialization, submitting every aspect of human existence to investor calculations about its future value. As we become human capital all the way down and all the way in, neoliberalism makes selling one's soul quotidian, rather than scandalous. And it reduces the remains of virtue to branding, for capital large and small. But economization, with its effect on values, is not the only problem here. Nihilism also has its way with the moral values project in neoliberalization

as it desublimates the will to power in morality.⁵ Here is how this goes.

As nihilism devalues values (voiding them of foundation and truth), it lessens the claim and force of conscience both formed and chained by values. More than simply making subjects less conscience bound, there is a cascading set of effects, the most important of which is the desublimation of the will to power. Recall that sublimation of the will to power, demanded by Judeo-Christian morality, includes turning the will against itself. This turning of the will to power inward, unleashing it on the subject, is what Nietzsche (and Freud, though differently) place at the seat of conscience. It is why both thinkers treat conscience as self-cruelty, not just self-containment. Conscience is the formation through which we internally attack and berate ourselves, not only restrain ourselves.

As the nihilistic devaluation of values lightens the force of conscience, it frees us from the restraint, self-blame, and self-abuse that conscience imposes. Desublimation sends the will to power outward again as it releases the subject from the lash and restraint of conscience. Hans Sluga puts it this way: “with nihilism, there is a falling back and collapse of the will to power into its own elementary form . . . even religion and the appeal to religious values become cynical instruments for the unrestrained use of power.”⁶ Yet more is at stake in this collapse than a will to power unbridled by humility or ethics. Rather, Sluga writes, “what also goes by the way in this unrestrained will to power is any concern for others . . . in particular the compact between generations on which our entire social order has rested so far.”⁷ If this desublimated force, tinged by the pain

of a wound (dethroned white masculinity) courses through traditional values politics today, we could not be further from the voluntary conformity with rules and spontaneous order that the neoliberal intellectuals counted on tradition to provide. It has turned into something else.

Not quite a century after Nietzsche wrote, Herbert Marcuse considered desublimation from a different angle to theorize the nonliberatory release of instinctual energies in postwar capitalism. What Marcuse famously termed “repressive desublimation” occurs within an order of capitalist domination, exploitation, and “false needs” as technology reduces the demands of necessity and as desire is everywhere incorporated into a commodity culture enjoyed by a growing middle class. This order features plenty of pleasure, including that obtained by radically reduced strictures on sexuality (less grueling work requires less sublimation), but does not feature emancipation. Instinctual energies, no longer directly opposed by the mandates of society and economy and thus no longer requiring heavy repression and sublimation, are now co-opted by and for capitalist production and marketing. As pleasure and especially sexuality are everywhere incorporated into capitalist culture, the pleasure principle and the reality principle slip their ancient antagonism.⁸ Pleasure, instead of being an insurrectionary challenge to the drudgery and exploitation of labor, becomes capital’s tool and generates submission.⁹ Far from dangerous or oppositional, no longer sequestered in aesthetics or utopian fantasy, pleasure becomes part of the machinery.

This much is familiar. Marcuse’s next turn in developing the implications of repressive desublimation, however, bears most

directly on our problem. According to Marcuse, nonliberatory desublimation facilitates “happy consciousness,” Hegel’s term for resolving the conflict between desire and social requirements by aligning one’s consciousness with the regime. Marcuse draws on Freud and Marx to radicalize Hegel’s formulation: in ordinary cultures of domination, Marcuse argues, “unhappy consciousness” is the effect of conscience—superegoic condemnation of “evil” urges in both self and society.¹⁰ Conscience is thus at once an element in the superego’s arsenal for internal restraint and a source of moral judgment about society. As repressive desublimation offers a reprieve from this strict censorship and gives rise to “happy consciousness” (a less divided self because a less conscientiously repressed one), conscience is the first casualty. Importantly, conscience relaxes not just in relation to the subject’s own conduct, but also in relation to social wrongs and ills . . . which are no longer registered as such. In other words, less repression in this context leads to a less demanding superego, which means less conscience, which, in an individualistic, unemancipated society, means less ethical-political concern across the board. In Marcuse’s words, “loss of conscience due to the satisfactory liberties granted by an unfree society makes for a *happy consciousness* which facilitates acceptance of the misdeeds of this society.” This loss of conscience “is the token of declining autonomy and comprehension.”¹¹

That desublimation lessens the force of conscience makes intuitive sense, but why does Marcuse associate this with the subject’s declining autonomy and intellectual comprehension? His complex point here differs from Freud’s argument in *Group Psychology and the Analysis of the Ego* that conscience weakens

when the subject effectively transfers it to an idealized leader or authority. For Marcuse, autonomy declines when comprehension declines (this is the cognitivist, if not the rationalist, in him), and comprehension declines when it is not required for survival and when the unemancipated subject is steeped in capitalist commodity pleasures and stimuli. Put the other way around, instinctual repression takes work, including the work of the intellect.¹² Therefore, as late capitalist desublimation relaxes demands against the instincts, but does not free the subject for self-direction, demands for intellection are substantially relaxed.¹³ Free, stupid, manipulable, absorbed by if not addicted to trivial stimuli and gratifications, the subject of repressive desublimation in advanced capitalist society is not just libidinally unbound, released to enjoy more pleasure, but released from more general expectations of social conscience and social comprehension. This release is amplified by the neo-liberal assault on the social and attack on intellectual knowledge as well as by the depression of conscience fostered by nihilism.

Repressive desublimation, Marcuse argues, is “part and parcel of the society in which it happens, but nowhere its negation.”¹⁴ It looks like freedom, but shores up the domination of the status quo. Its expressions, Marcuse says, may be bold or vulgar enough even to appear as maverick or dissident—it may be “wild and obscene, virile and tasty, quite immoral.”¹⁵ However, this daring and disinhibition (manifest today in Alt-Right tweets, blogs, trolling, and public conduct) symptomizes or iterates, rather than counters the order’s violence and prejudices, as well as its ordinary values.¹⁶ In Marcuse’s view, repressive

desublimation twins “freedom and oppression,” transgression and submission, in a distinctive way, as is apparent in the wild, raging, and even outlaw expressions of patriotism and nationalism frequently erupting from the extreme Right today.¹⁷

Repressive desublimation also unleashes new levels and perhaps even new forms of violence through opening the spigot of that other well of human instinct, Thanatos. Desublimation of Eros is compatible, Marcuse argues, “with the growth of unsublimated as well as sublimated forms of aggressiveness.”¹⁸ Why? Because repressive desublimation doesn’t release Eros for freedom *tout court*, but instead involves a compression or concentration of erotic energy at the site of sexuality—this is part of what makes it “controlled” or “repressive” desublimation. Desublimated Eros may therefore bestir, blend with, and even intensify aggression. Thus Marcuse explains growing accommodation or acquiescence to social and political violence—a “degree of normalization where . . . individuals are getting used to the risk of their own dissolution and disintegration.”¹⁹ His own reference was to the mid-twentieth-century Cold War nuclear weapons buildup, but the point is easily adapted for accommodation to world-ending climate change and other existential threats. Most importantly for our purposes, his insight is suggestive for understanding the quantity and intensity of aggression spilling from the Right, especially the Alt-Right, amidst its frenzied affirmation of individual freedom, about which more shortly.

Finally, there is Marcuse’s account of the role of the market in intensifying the nihilism theorized by Nietzsche. Writing well before the neoliberal revolution, Marcuse argues that the market has become both reality principle and moral truth: “The

people are led to find in the productive apparatus”—the market—“the effective agent of thought and action to which their personal thought and action can and must be surrendered,” and “in this transfer, the apparatus also assumes the role of a moral agent. Conscience is absolved by reification, by the general necessity of things. In this general necessity, guilt has no place.”²⁰ Already depleted by desublimation yielding a happy consciousness, the weak remains of conscience are taken over by market reason and market requirements. The real is both the rational and the moral. At once reality principle, imperative, and moral order, capitalism becomes necessity, authority, and truth rolled into one; suffusing every sphere and immune from criticism, despite its manifest devastations, incoherencies, and instabilities. There is no alternative.

Bringing Marcuse’s version together with Nietzsche’s, the historically specific nihilistic depletion of conscience and desublimation of the will to power perhaps explains several things. To begin with, it may animate what is commonly called a resurgence of tribalism, but is better framed as a broken relation to the world demographically outside and temporally after one’s own. It may be the decoding key for Melania Trump’s infamous “I really don’t care, do u?” emblazoned Zara jacket worn on her visit to migrant children separated from their parents at the Texas border. It may explain the routinized mocking, on right-wing websites and in comments sections, of “libtard” concern with human suffering, injustice, or ecological devastation. In *Strangers in Their Own Land*, Arlie Hochschild sympathetically recounts her right-wing interviewees desire to be free “from the strictures of liberal philosophy and its rules of feeling.” They felt

they were being asked “to feel compassion for the downtrodden” when “they didn’t want to,” although they identified as devout Christians.²¹ They spurned environmentalism on similar grounds (and because it involved big government) notwithstanding the devastation of their health and habitat resulting from polluting industries.²² Refracting this politics of indifference through the nihilistic disintegration of a social compact and through lost faith in capacities to control human powers and arrangements takes us beyond Hochschild’s inclination to root this sentiment in her subjects’ experience of social and political neglect. It explains their attraction to leaders calling for aggressive door-slamming to “outsiders” and a humanly habitable future, leaders who build this sentiment into an affirmative political passion animated by a desublimated will to power. It explains why such policies are celebrated with gleeful, vengeful rallying cries. The wreckage that nihilism makes of conscience may also help explain the unprecedented aggression and viciousness emanating from right-wing cable and internet news, blogs, and tweets. This aggression and viciousness is fed by neoliberal valorization of libertarian freedom, by wounded, angry white maleness, and by nihilism’s radical depression of conscience and social obligation.²³ It is discursively organized by neoliberal assaults on the social and the political and by neoliberal legitimation of indifference to the predicaments or fate of other humans, other species, or the planet. However, attacks on liberals and leftists, feminists, antiracists, and others are also a nihilistic form of action. The passion and pleasure in trolling and trashing are signs of what Nietzsche called “wreaking the will” simply to feel its power when world

affirmation or world building are unavailable. Perhaps negation—whether crude or moralistic—is what remains when the powers shaping the world appear uncontrollable and uncontainable, and existential doom appears imminent. Again, however, it is important to register the active quality of this negation: right-wing spurning of ethical or political enjoinders to care for or repair the world is a form of “doing.” And, as Nietzsche points out, “there is so much that is festive” in it—especially in the pleasures of provocation and piling on, of humiliating others or making them suffer, of dancing at the bonfires of what one is burning down.²⁴

In this consequential turn, where nihilism intersects neoliberalism, freedom is torn out of the habitus in traditional values by which it was to be contained and disciplined in the original neoliberal formation. The combination of neoliberalism’s deprecation of the political and the social and a desublimated, wounded white masculinity together generate a disinhibited freedom, one symptomizing ethical destitution even as it often dresses in religious righteousness or conservative melancholy for a phantasmatic past. This freedom is paradoxically expressed as nihilism and against nihilism, attacking and destroying while faulting its objects of derision for the ruin of traditional values and order. It is freedom unbridled and uncultured, freedom to put a stick in the eye of accepted norms, freedom from care of the morrow. This is the freedom remaindered by nihilism, in the making for centuries and intensified by neoliberalism itself. It is the freedom of “I will because I can, because I believe in nothing and I am nothing other than my will to power.”²⁵ This is humanity without a project other than revenge, without

restraint by conscience, faith, or value and without belief in either human or divine purposes. One extreme expression of such subject production and orientation may be the so-called “incel” movement, composed of men whose wrath at being spurned or ignored by women is turned against the women themselves through online aggressions such as trolling and Gamergate, but also in the form of terror attacks such as those in Isla Vista and Toronto.²⁶ Here, desublimation permits what was formerly the material of shame, misery, and self-loathing to be acted out as murderous rage. At the same time, the movement draws on a nihilistic version of moral traditionalism, “before feminism,” in which male sexual access to women was a matter of right.

Attention to the desublimated will to power in subjects and morality itself would explain another feature of the present, namely, how the Right, with its values agenda, routinely survives the moral scandals so frequently enveloping its religious and political leaders, indeed, survives them better than the Left. Why were Clinton’s blowjobs from an intern more damaging to his presidency than Trump’s pussy grabbing, assault allegations from Miss Universe contestants, peeing prostitutes, and affairs with porn actresses and *Playboy* bunnies have been to his—especially given their respective constituencies? How does a right-wing Supreme Court justice nominee survive allegations that would have taken down a Democratic nominee in a heartbeat? One answer is that nihilism depresses the significance of conduct, consistency, and truth: one no longer need be moral, only shout about it. Another is that nihilism makes values politics contractual: Trump’s evangelical base does not care who he

is or what he does so long as he delivers on Jerusalem, abortion, the trans ban in the military, prayer in school, and the rights of Christian businesses and individuals to discriminate. As we saw in chapter 3, there is plenty of evidence that both sides understand this deal.²⁷ Evangelical leader Pat Robertson also makes the contractualism explicit. Responding to Saudi Arabia's murder of the journalist Jamal Khashoggi, he wrote, "For those who are screaming blood for the Saudis—look, these people are key allies . . . it'll be a lot of jobs, a lot of money come to our coffers. It's not something you want to blow up willy-nilly."²⁸

However, neither the contractualism nor the decreased importance of moral consistency tap the most important feature of nihilism here. Nihilism releases the will to power not only in subjects, but in traditional values themselves, baldly revealing the privilege and entitlement they encode, their raw power purposes and energies. Thus, morality, too, "falls back" to its elementary form, its will to power, as nihilism shatters its foundations and devalues its value. Pussy grabbing, adultery, consorting with prostitutes, scamming contractors and undocumented workers—these are rights of the powerful that traditional values implicitly license as they explicitly prohibit, encode as they disavow.²⁹ If the power purposes in traditional morality are enormous, they are what remain when nihilism takes its Sermon on the Mount drapery off. More, for constituencies anxious about their ebbing place and privilege, nothing is more reassuring than Trump's crass sexual entitlement to all women, the crude contractualism of his marriage, and for that matter, all of his crude conduct and flaunting of law and the protocols of the presidency . . . none of which a female or nonwhite

politician could emit and survive for a nanosecond—which is precisely the point. Trump’s boorishness and rule breaking, far from being at odds with traditional values, consecrates the white male supremacy at their heart, whose waning is a crucial spur to his support.

Nihilism and Ressentiment

In addition to nihilism, Nietzsche is the master theorist of another symptom of our age—suffering experienced as wrongful victimization. He posited whole moral systems born from suffering and rage, offering a formulation of ressentiment as the basis of their emergence and unfolding. Again, we will have to revise Nietzsche here, since waning entitlement, aggrieved supremacy, and not merely the frustrations of what he called “weakness” are at the heart of these logics today, but let us reprise his account first.

Judeo-Christian morality, Nietzsche suggests in the first essay of *On the Genealogy of Morals*, was born as the revenge of the weak, those who suffered in a value system affirming strength, power, and action. The weak were resentful not of their own weakness, but of the strong, whom they (mistakenly) blamed for their suffering. And so they invented a new value system in which strength would be reproached as evil and weakness lofted as good.³⁰ The invention of this new value system, Nietzsche says, occurs when ressentiment stops seething long enough to “become creative and give birth to values.”³¹ The weak cannot act, only react; this is what their moralizing

critique is, and because it is all they have, they will pursue it doggedly until it triumphs. Thus does a Judeo-Christian valorization of meekness, humility, self-abnegation, and asceticism, but also equality and democracy, emanate from the wound of weakness and take down the strong and the powerful, whom this new morality constrains and punishes. Again, the creature of resentment, in its incapacity to make the world, reproaches the world it blames for its suffering and humiliation, thereby anesthetizing their sting. This means the moral system it builds has rancor, reproach, negation, and even revenge at its heart.

Ressentiment, rancor, rage, reaction to humiliation and suffering—certainly all of these are at play in right-wing populism and support for authoritarian leadership today. However, this politics of resentment emerges from the historically dominant as they feel that dominance ebbing—as whiteness, especially, but also masculinity provides limited protection against the displacements and losses that forty years of neoliberalism have yielded for the working and middle classes. This resentment thus varies from Nietzschean logics rooted in the psychic vicissitudes of weakness. Though linked by humiliation, the frustrations of weakness (existential or historical) and of aggrieved power are worlds apart, obvious enough in the radically different responses by working-class whites and working-class blacks to the displacements and demotions delivered by neoliberal economic effects. Only the former is aggrieved by its dethronement.

And yet there is an important aspect of the neoliberalization of everyday life that salts this wound: the deep inequality of

access and hierarchies of status organizing every part of commerce and what remains of public life. As works such as Michael J. Sandel's *What Money Can't Buy* argue, today there is hardly a contemporary activity or sphere of life unstriated by tiers or classes of access dependent on wealth: from boarding an airplane to the legroom and food inside it; from access to sports events to access to uncongested highway lanes; from who obtains family leave in a corporation to who obtains an MRI authorized by their health insurance; from how quickly you can renew a passport, get on to the rides at Disney World, or get your offspring into rehab.³² These stratifications are written so deeply into contemporary culture that they are an essential part of branding: the lousiest motel chains have "premier lounges," and "upgrade" is a ubiquitous term in every industry and service. The more of public life that is privatized—national parks, education, roads, emergency, schools, and other city services—the more this inequality heaps up the have-nots into crowded underserved piles of misery while offering the haves (the top 30 percent, not the top 1 percent) every possible way to buy their way out of crowding, waiting, and suffering.

Wealth-determined stratification of access and provision is hardly new under the sun. But neoliberal privatization and legitimation of inequality make it more intense, more widely disseminated, and more deeply penetrated into everyday life than at any time since feudalism. The tiered pricing of service, access, and treatment for everything everywhere accustoms all to inegalitarianism and makes us more feudal than democratic in subjectivity and ethos. This phenomenon also surely

intensifies the anger of the dethroned, when Boarding Group 1 passengers, exuding cosmopolitanism along with the importance conferred by rank, push past the middle-aged white couples from the fly-over states smashed together in Boarding Group 5. Attention to such effects resets the tired Left debate about whether right-wing populism today is born of class or other kinds of resentment, whether it is the rage of the economically left behinds or the rage of dethroned white masculinity. The neoliberalization of everyday life—not merely its inequalitarian effects, but also its relentlessly inequalitarian spirit—richly compounds the two.

What happens when resentment is born of dethronement, from lost entitlement, rather than from weakness? I want to offer two speculations.

First possibility: the rancor and rage are not developed into refined moral values, but remain rancor and rage. They are not sublimated into the Christian self-abnegation and love of thy neighbor that Nietzsche treats as the apex (or nadir) of the process he accounts for in *On the Genealogy of Morals*. Suffering and humiliation, resentment unsublimated, become a permanent politics of revenge, of attacking those blamed for dethroned white maleness—feminists, multiculturalists, globalists, who both unseat and disdain them. The unstanched wound and unsublimated rage, combined with a nihilism that mocks in advance all values, means that high levels of affect, not developed moral systems, not what Nietzsche called “unprecedented cleverness” building whole systems of critique, animate populations mobilized by them. This is raw resentment without the

turn toward discipline, creativity, and ultimately, intellectual mastery that Nietzsche tracks as slave morality in building Judeo-Christian civilization. This is resentment without diversion into clever critiques and refined moral logics that invert by reproaching domination. This is resentment stuck in its trapped rancor, unable to “become creative.” It has only revenge, no way out, no futurity.

It is significant that Trump himself identifies revenge as his sole philosophy of life: revenge and nothing else, revenge without end, because there is nothing else.³³ Beyond efforts to destroy anyone who questions or opposes him, revenge saturates his so-called agenda and is also what satisfies the basest part of his base. It animates the drive to overturn every Obama-era achievement, of course, from climate accords to the Iran deal, but also to destroy what those policies aimed at protecting or preserving: the earth and its many species, the rights and protections of the vulnerable (LGBT, women, minorities), and the health of Americans secured through Obamacare.³⁴

It is also significant that many Trump supporters, when interviewed about his lies, affairs, flouting of truth or law, say “I don’t care. I’m tired of the disrespect his opponents have for him and for me.”³⁵ What kind of defense of your man is this? Insofar as it eschews reasons and values, it, too, expresses nihilism. Insofar as it expresses a wound as the basis of an attachment, it puts into discourse resentment toward those they know are the real winners today: those in Boarding Groups 1 and 2. In affirming the propriety of respect for the president,

regardless of his conduct, it reiterates the hollowness of “support for the troops” fighting wars no one believes in—loyalty to the shell of what was once filled with value. In confessing that Trump embodies a retort to their pain, it explains why it does not matter what policies he pursues, only that he opposes those they hold responsible for their suffering. In fact, his abuses of power—marital and political—are vital to this desire, not at cross purposes with it. He has power they lack and is nothing but the will to power. His base knows this, needs this, electing him not for moral rectitude, let alone political competence, but for revenge against the wound of nothingness by destroying the imagined agent of that wound. This is resentment in a nasty stew with nihilism.

Second possibility: a table of values does in fact emerge from the resentment of those suffering the lost entitlements of historically conferred power. If Nietzsche is right that resentment of the weak redeems its predicament by naming “evil” what it holds responsible for its pain and naming itself “good,” then dethroned entitlement would denounce equality and even merit in order to affirm its supremacy based on nothing more than traditional right. “Make America Great Again,” “France for the French,” “Pure Poland, White Poland”—all the right-wing slogans express this. In affirming supremacy and entitlement based on past supremacy and entitlement, these formations perform a historic inversion of values to close out three centuries of modern experiments with democracy. Indeed, they attack the very Judeo-Christian morality whose production Nietzsche charted, suggesting a completion of what nihilism began. They

stage supremacy now as a raw entitlement claim—a staging that converges powerfully with neoliberalism's assault on equality and democracy, the social and the political.

The white male supremacy in contemporary traditional values politics becomes explicit, then, not only because nihilism pulls the moral drapery off those values and makes them contractual or instrumentalizable, but also because this supremacy has been wounded without being destroyed. Its subject abhors the democracy it holds responsible for its wounds and seeks to pull democracy down as it goes down.

Perhaps we are also witnessing how nihilism goes when futurity itself is in doubt. Perhaps there is a form of nihilism shaped by the waning of a type of social dominance or the waning social dominance of a historical type. As this type finds itself in a world emptied not only of meaning, but of its own place, far from going gently into the night, it turns toward apocalypse. If white men cannot own democracy, there will be no democracy. If white men cannot rule the planet, there will be no planet. Nietzsche was immensely curious about what would come after the two centuries of the intensifying nihilism he expected. But what if there is no "after"? What if supremacy is the rosary held tight as white civilization itself appears finished and takes with it all futurity? What if this is how it ends?

Nihilism for Nietzsche emanates from the death of God. Inaugurating the recognition that humans make their own meanings, values, worlds, we first shift our reverence from God to man and then lose faith in what we have created ourselves as groundless and contingent. Moreover, as he writes in *On the Genealogy of Morals*, we have been made small and miserable,

rather than noble and happy through the building of Judeo-Christian civilization and thus have grown weary of man: “together with the fear of man we have also lost our love of him, our reverence for him, our hopes for him, even the will to him.” As a result, “what is nihilism today if is not that?—We are weary *of man*.”³⁶

However, as I discussed at the beginning of this chapter, Nietzsche’s account of nihilism, in which first God and then man is toppled as foundational sources of truth and morality, is inadequate to our present. Other things inflect nihilism’s contemporary course and manifestations. Today, for example, nihilism intensifies in a world that reflects humanity as having brought the species to unprecedented misery and the planet to the brink of destruction. “Man” has not merely lost value or stable meaning, but is indicted by myriad powers generated, but not controlled by humans, powers that diminish, mock, reproach, and endanger us, not only devalue us. We appear not only without nobility and greatness, but without even the ability to provide for ourselves or clean up after ourselves. A species of giant toddlers, appetitive for power, pleasure, and play, we have yet to become responsible for our creations, our history. The paradox of humanly created powers that diminish the human by revealing our incapacity to direct our fates or even preserve ourselves and our habitat, reaching new heights as these powers are revealed as all that makes the world—this breeds a nihilism beyond Nietzsche’s wildest imagination. Charting nihilism as emanating from the desacralization and hence devaluation of values, Nietzsche did not take the measure of the formations and effects of power that trivialize and mock

humans themselves, at which point nihilism intersects with fatalism, apocalypticism, or despair. Little wonder that rapture Christianity, with its end-times eschatology, is the religion of the age.³⁷

Space

If neoliberalism is conceived only as economic policy and effects, the frame for discontent is limited to economic factors—growing inequality, deindustrialization, loss of union jobs and of the provisions of the social state. The resulting analysis focuses on the “left behind,” especially the economic and political neglect of the white working and middle class generated by a rising tide of elites, cosmopolitans, and the beneficiaries of identity politics. If neoliberalism is conceived only as a political rationality featuring the ubiquity of markets and *homo oeconomicus* (my claim in *Undoing the Demos*), we cannot grasp the affective investments in privileges of whiteness and First World existence in the nation and national culture or in traditional morality. We also cannot grasp the ways that the hierarchies and exclusions of “tradition” legitimately challenged democratic equality in the name of both family values and freedom. This means that we cannot grasp the new formations of subjectivity and politics that are, in good part, neoliberal effects. At the same time, we cannot grasp what the forces are that neoliberalism accidentally intersects or instigates and thus what it produces inadvertently and even against its own aims. These are the kinds of genealogical emergences (to use Michel Foucault’s

language) or conjunctures (to use Stuart Hall's) occluded by historiographies bound to progress, regression, dialectics, or determinism.³⁸ They may be complex to map and narrate, but without them, we remain lost.

Above all, when neoliberalism is reduced to economic policy or rationality, it blinds us to three tectonic shifts in the organization and consciousness of space that both spur certain political reactions today and organize the theater in which they occur. The first of these shifts is the lost horizon of the nation-state consequent to globalization. From capital flows to immigrant flows, from digital networks to supply chains, the world has invaded the nation, weakening its borders and its sovereignty, redistributing production and consumption, and transforming the existential conditions and prospects of every kind of population—rural, suburban, and urban. If this shift has incited rancor against both new immigrants and the politics and politicians held responsible for allowing them into the West, it is also producing a divide between those accommodating the shift and those furiously rebelling against it.

The second spatial shift involves the neoliberal destruction of the social discussed in chapter 2. As neoliberalism dissolves that sphere into a market order, on the one hand, and a familial one, on the other, the space of civic equality and concern with the common good that democracy requires disappears. At the same time, the rise of the digital generates a novel, radically deterritorialized and dedemocratized sociality. This sociality features no clear protocols of power sharing, enfranchisement, or commitment to negotiating diverse views and needs, inclusion, or plurality. Whatever their merits, digitalized "societies" are

detached from the challenge of sharing power equally in order to rule ourselves. They may have other democratizing potentials, but they are not themselves substitutes for democratic practices and the political equality they require.

The third spatial shift pertains to the rise of finance capital and the modality of value that it ushers into the world. Multi-national corporations and global assembly lines of post-Fordism already challenged the visibility and tangibility of capital ownership and control. However, the vaporous powers of finance, which rule everything, but live nowhere, are akin to a Copernican revolution for subjectivity in relation to the powers making and governing the world. Indeed, just as the round earth cannot be seen, but can be known only deductively, through its effects, rule by finance involves a transformation of spatial consciousness that paradoxically hinges on the despatialization of power as such, not only the deterritorialization identified with globalization in its early decades.

One popular account of the effects of all three shifts is encapsulated by British pundit David Goodhart's notion of "somewheres" and "nowheres."³⁹ "Somewheres" are people rooted in a specific place or community, rural or suburban, generally have limited education and exposure to the world, and harbor conservative social views. "Anywheres" he depicts as relatively rootless, urban, and urbane; they tend to be more educated, progressive, and open to the future. With this popular demography, Goodhart aims to offer a geopolitical wellspring for contemporary political divides—one that exceeds the conventions of beneficiaries versus victims of globalization, but that also attempts to bypass the conventional framing of the urban/

rural divide in which those who profit from globalization are pitted against those who are devastated by it and those inhabiting multicultural milieus are divided from those who heretofore inhabited homogenous white worlds or long-standing racially hierarchicalized ones. With this map and lexicon, Goodhart seeks to bring into relief the political divide between those who experience profound threats to their demographic rootedness, on the one hand (the somewheres) and those he casts as born into or at least embracing an urban, cosmopolitan, deterritorialized existence, on the other (the nowheres). The different horizons and affects he aims to encode with this division of the world distinguish between those who cling to place and those who have embraced globalization—culturally, socially, economically, and politically.

Goodhart's map is overdrawn and occludes important features. However, like Hochschild's figure of "strangers in their own land," it captures an aspect of subjective white Western reaction to globalization. To develop Goodhart's thesis, Carl Schmitt is again helpful because of his close attention to the ontological implications of space. In *Land and Sea* and *Dialogue on Power and Space* Schmitt throws down this provocation: humans are land mammals and orient themselves through land demarcation and organization.⁴⁰ A close relationship to the earth secures both ground and horizon for humans. It orients humanity toward demarcation, possession, and lineage, which are concretely achieved through property, house, marriage, family and inheritance. In contrast, efforts to extend sovereignty through or across the sea and even develop livelihoods from the sea orient people differently: toward boundarylessness, but also

toward use and consumption, rather than ownership and cultivation.⁴¹ Schmitt is thinking here not only about the difference between fishing and farming, extraction and reproduction, but about how and why sea-surrounded England becomes an empire and how all the coastal nations of Europe attempt infinite outward expansion, while other European peoples and nations remain oriented toward Europe.⁴² By his own acknowledgment, he is responding to Hegel's remark in the *Philosophy of Right* that land "is the condition for the principle of family life," while "for industry the outward enlivening natural element in the sea," and he is openly wrestling with the fusion of industry and colonization that Hegel mirrors from his time.⁴³ In this discussion, Schmitt's wariness of seafaring people but also of denationalization is palpable: loss of ground entails loss of boundary and horizon, loss of ties to the local across time, loss of the primacy of family, tradition, religion. Blood and soil indeed.

Schmitt knows this speculative history does not stay confined to actual peoples and places and that there is, rather, a transformation of (European) consciousness that comes with discovery of the New World, the Copernican Revolution, and the "spatial revolution" that "involves a change in the concepts of space encompassing all the levels and domains of human existence."⁴⁴ "It is no overstatement," he writes, "to claim that all domains of life, all forms of existence, all kinds of human creative force, art, science, and technology partake in the new concept of space."⁴⁵ It even becomes the foundation of Occidental rationalism that "advances irresistibly" and destroys "the medieval forms of human community, builds new states, fleets,

and armies, invents new machines, subjugates the non-European peoples, and places them before the dilemma of either adopting European civilization or of descending to the status of a mere colonial people.”⁴⁶

However problematically, incompletely, and tendentiously, Schmitt anticipates the experience of globalization by Goodhart’s “somewheres” for whom attachments to nation, family, property, and whiteness are mobilized as a politically reactionary formation. Missing from both accounts is the toxic mix of nihilism, fatalism, and resentment with neoliberal assaults on the social and the political and valorization of markets and morals that this book limns. Frightened by the loss of values and goods heretofore secured by the “*nomos* of the earth,” this population rages against secular cosmopolitans oriented toward use in place of ownership and embracing racial indeterminacy, gender fluidity, “families we choose,” godlessness, open borders, speculation, virtual sociality, and the rootlessness of everyday life. The somewheres cling to the soil, even if it is planted in suburban lawn devastated by droughts and floods from global warming, littered with the paraphernalia of addictive painkillers, and adjacent to crumbling schools, abandoned factories, terminal futures. Families become shells, ownership and savings vanish, marriages teeter and break, depression, anxiety, and other forms of mental illness are ubiquitous, religion is commercialized and weaponized, and patriotism is reduced to xenophobic support for troops in aimless, endless wars and useless, but spectacular border barricades. Nation, family, property, and the traditions reproducing racial and gender privilege, mortally

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wounded by deindustrialization, neoliberal reason, globalization, digital technologies, and nihilism, are reduced to affective remains. To date, these remains have been activated mostly by the Right. What kinds of Left political critique and vision might reach and transform them?